490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 3 OF 26

Creation and the Image of God

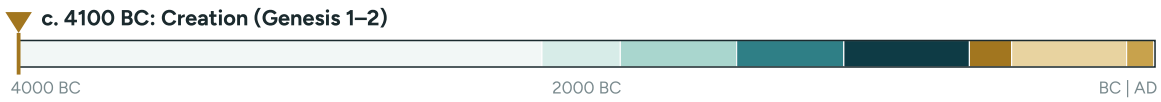
Genesis 1–2 · Psalm 8



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 3



Introduction: What Are People For?

Clean out an old man's garage after he dies and you will find things you cannot name. A bent piece of iron with a wooden handle. A brass fitting shaped like nothing you have ever seen. You can turn it over in your hands all afternoon and never figure out what it was for. The only one who could tell you is the one who made it.

That is the situation every human being is in. We are here, and we did not make ourselves, and the question underneath almost every other question we ask is this: what am I for? Our culture gives a hundred answers. You are for being happy. You are for achieving. You are for being true to yourself. You are a lucky accident and you are for nothing at all. Every one of those answers is a guess made from the inside, by the thing itself, turning itself over in its own hands.

Genesis 1 and 2 are the Maker's answer. Last week we met the God who is there: eternal, holy, needing nothing, one God in three persons. This week we watch him make a world, and then make us, and we hear him say what we are for. If you get this lesson, you will understand why people matter, why work matters, why your body matters, why marriage matters, and why the world is so beautiful. Next week we will see why it also feels so wrong.

The Word: Image

> **Genesis 1:26–27** *"Then God said, 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.' So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them."*

צֶלֶם *(tselem, "image")*

a carved or cast likeness that stands for someone; paired here with "likeness"

צֶלֶם (tselem)

"image"

Elsewhere it means a statue or idol: the "images" of Baal (2 Kings 11:18), and in Aramaic the golden image Nebuchadnezzar set up (Dan. 3:1).

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דְּמוּת (demut)

"likeness"

Resemblance. When Adam later has a son, Seth is born "in his own likeness, after his image" (Gen. 5:3). Image and likeness carry the idea of sonship.

Payoff: Ancient kings set up images of themselves in lands they ruled, so everyone would know whose land it was. And a ninth-century BC statue of a ruler found in Syria uses the Aramaic forms of these same two words, image and likeness, for the king's statue. Now read Genesis 1 again. God made the whole world as his kingdom, and then, as the last thing he made, he set his own image in it. He set a living man and woman, not stone or gold, made to show the world what its King is like and to rule it under him. No wonder Israel was later forbidden to carve images of God (Ex. 20:4; Deut. 4:15–16). He had already made his image, and it walks on two legs.

Keep that picture. Every person you have ever met is a living statue of the King, set in his world to represent him. Every one of us has defaced it, some more visibly than others, but none have ceased to bear it. That one word answers the garage question. You are for God: to know him, reflect him, and rule his world on his behalf.



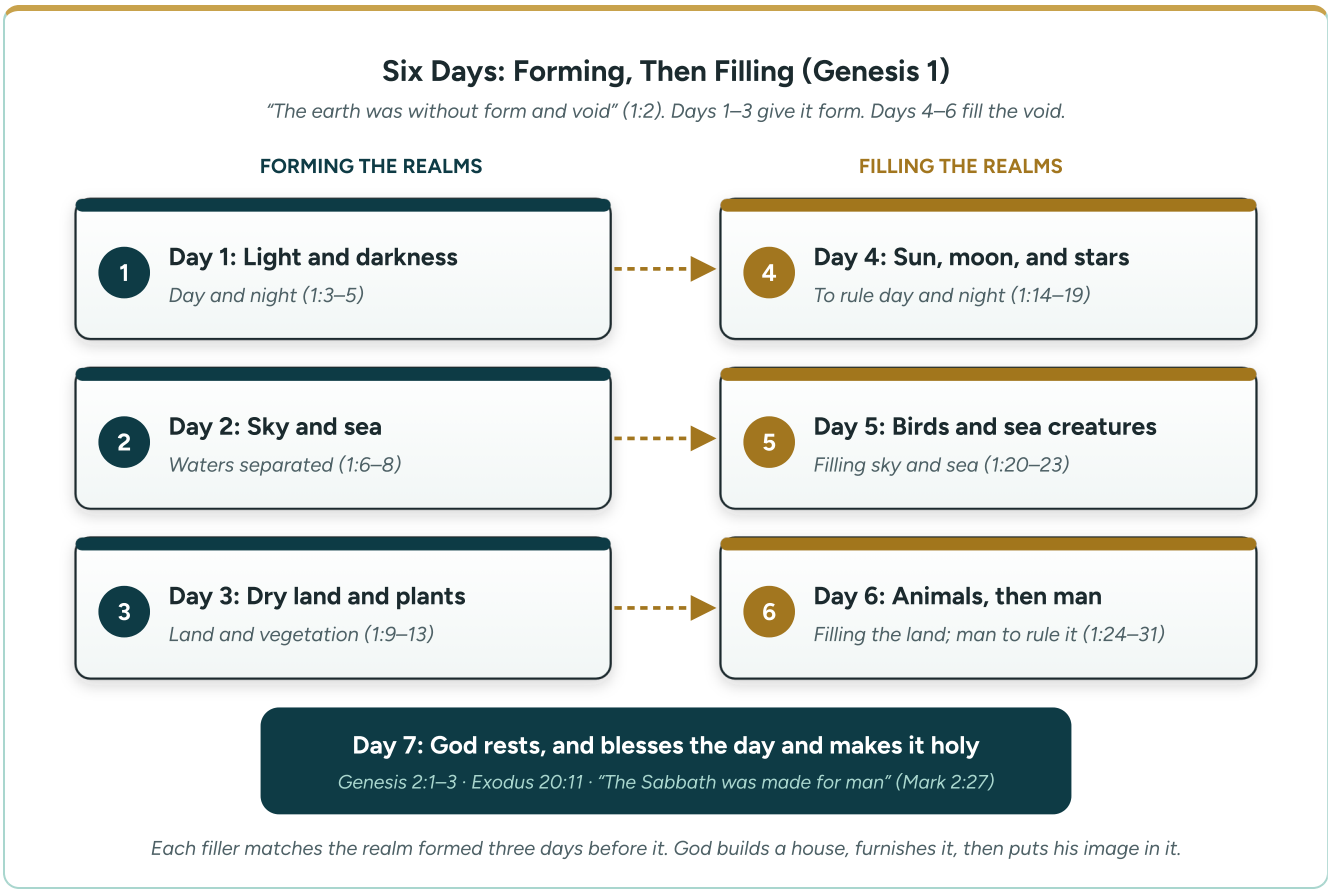
An ancient king's image marked his land as his. God set his own living image in the world he made.

Part One: Out of Nothing, by a Word

> **Genesis 1:1–3** *"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth. The earth was without form and void, and darkness was over the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters. And God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light."*

Notice how God makes things. He speaks. Ten times in the chapter you read "And God said," and whenever he commands something into being, it happens. A psalm puts it in one line: "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:9). He did not shape the world out of something that was already lying around. "By faith we understand that the universe was created by the word of God, so that what is seen was not made out of things that are visible" (Heb. 11:3). Theologians use a Latin phrase for this, *ex nihilo*: out of nothing. The Shorter Catechism puts it plainly: "The work of creation is, God's making all things of nothing, by the word of his power, in the space of six days, and all very good" (WSC 9).

Verse 2 gives us two problems, and the rest of the chapter solves them. The earth was "without form" (shapeless, not yet ordered) and "void" (empty, not yet filled). Watch what God does over the six days. On the first three days he forms: he separates light from darkness, sky from sea, and dry land from water. On the next three days he fills what he formed: lights for the day and night, birds for the sky and fish for the sea, animals for the land. And last, he makes the man and the woman to rule it all. Then on the seventh day he rests.



The pattern is in the text itself, and it shows you a God of order and generosity. He builds a house, then furnishes it, then puts someone in it to live. Nothing in Genesis 1 is random. Everything is made "according to its kind," put in its place, and called good.

How long were those days? This study takes them as ordinary days of evening and morning, and the Westminster Confession says God created "in the space of six days" (WCF 4.1). God himself ties the Sabbath (the weekly day of rest he later gave Israel) to those days when he speaks the Ten Commandments: "For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested on the seventh day" (Ex. 20:11). You should know that faithful Reformed teachers have read the days in other ways, as long ages or as a literary framework, and a person can love Christ and hold the Bible as God's Word whichever of these views he holds. What every one of them holds, and what matters most, is the main thing Genesis 1 teaches: the one true God made everything there is, by his word, on purpose, and it was good.

Also read: *Psalm 104; Psalm 33:6–9; John 1:1–3; Colossians 1:15–17; Revelation 4:11*

Part Two: Very Good



"And out of the ground the LORD God made to spring up every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food" (Gen. 2:9).

Six times in Genesis 1 God looks at what he has made and sees that it is good. The seventh time comes after he makes the man and the woman: "And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good" (Gen. 1:31).

Let that correct something many religious people believe. Some think the body is a prison for the soul, that matter is dirty and only the "spiritual" is holy, that the real goal is to escape this world. That is an old idea, and the Bible rejects it from the first page. God made trees "pleasant to the sight and good for food" (Gen. 2:9). He made bodies. He made taste and color and the smell of rain. He made work and marriage and rest. Paul says it bluntly to Timothy about teachers who forbade marriage and certain foods: "For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving" (1 Tim. 4:3–4).

And the world was made for someone. The New Testament tells us who did the making: "For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible… all things were created through him and for him" (Col. 1:16). The "him" is Jesus. The Son through whom God spoke the world into being is the same Son the world was made for. When you enjoy a good meal, a sunrise, or the laughter of a child, you are enjoying a gift that was made through Christ and for Christ. That is why gratitude is the right response, and why the world's goodness is meant to lead you back to its Giver.

Part Three: In Our Image

Every plant and animal in Genesis 1 is made "according to its kind." Only one creature is made after God's likeness: "in our image, after our likeness." And God pauses before he does it. For every other creature he says, "Let there be," or "Let the earth bring forth." Here he says, "Let us make." The whole chapter slows down for this.

What does it mean to be made in God's image? The Shorter Catechism answers: "God created man male and female, after his own image, in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, with dominion over the creatures" (WSC 10). Unpack that, and read it beside Genesis 1:27, and you find three things.

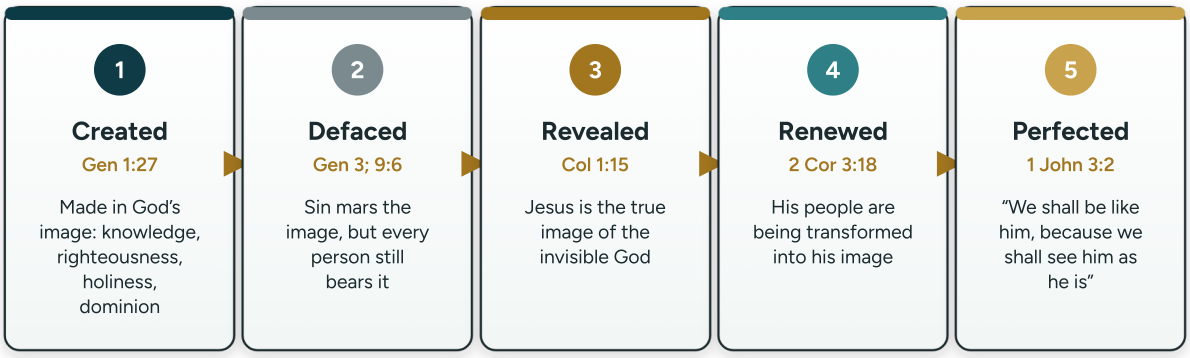
We were made to reflect God's character. The first man and woman knew God truly, did what was right, and were holy, set apart for him. The New Testament confirms this when it describes salvation as the image being restored: the new self "is being renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator" (Col. 3:10), "created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness" (Eph. 4:24). That is why the New Testament speaks of renewal. Sin did not erase the image, but it ruined the knowledge, righteousness, and holiness that made it shine. Every person still bears God's image. Only in Christ is it being made new.

We were made to rule God's world on his behalf. "Let them have dominion" is the very next phrase after "in our image." Think back to the king's statue. Adam and Eve were God's representatives, appointed to care for his world the way a good king cares for his realm. Dominion is a gardener's rule, as Genesis 2 will show.

We were made male and female, to bear the image together. "Male and female he created them." The image is not the man alone or the woman alone. Both bear it fully and equally, and they were made for each other. The righteousness the Catechism names was never a private thing. Jesus summed up God's law as love for God and love for neighbor (Matt. 22:37–39), and from the first day God's image was meant to live out that love side by side.

This one truth changes how you look at every person. The unborn child knit together in the womb (Ps. 139:13–14). The person with a disability who will never hold a job. The elderly man who no longer remembers your name. The person of another nation and color, since God "made from one man every nation of mankind" (Acts 17:26). Your enemy. Even after sin entered the world, God still grounded the value of human life in his image: "Whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for God made man in his own image" (Gen. 9:6). James warns against cursing "people who are made in the likeness of God" (James 3:9). C. S. Lewis once said there are no ordinary people. He was right. Every one of them is a living statue of the King.

The Story of the Image of God



"For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son" (Rom 8:29).

CORE DOCTRINE 3 OF 26

Creation and the Image of God

God made everything out of nothing by his word, and it was very good. He made human beings, male and female, in his own image, to know him, reflect his character, and care for his world. Every human life carries that dignity.

KEY VERSES

Genesis 1:1, 26–28, 31; Psalm 8; Hebrews 11:3

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"I believe in God the Father Almighty, Maker of heaven and earth." (Apostles' Creed)
"God created man male and female, after his own image, in knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, with dominion over the creatures." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 10)

WHY IT MATTERS

You are not an accident, and neither is anyone you meet. Every person you see bears God's image and deserves honor.

Part Four: The Garden

Genesis 2 tells the creation of man again, this time up close. Chapter 1 is the wide shot: the whole universe, and humanity at the top of it. Chapter 2 is the close-up: one man, one garden, one woman, one command.

You may notice two things as you read. First, the name changes. Genesis 1 calls him "God." Genesis 2 calls him "the LORD God," using the personal name we met at the burning bush last week. The God who made the stars is the God who comes close and makes promises. Second, some readers say Genesis 1 and 2 are two different creation stories that do not agree. They are one story told twice: first the whole week from far away, then the sixth day up close. Chapter 2 is not trying to give the order of all creation. It slows down to show how God made the man and the woman and set them in their home.

> **Genesis 2:7** *"then the LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living creature."*



"The LORD God formed the man of dust from the ground" (Gen. 2:7). The word for "formed" is the word for a potter's work.

Two things come together in you. Dust: you are made of the same stuff as the ground, humble and fragile. And breath: the life in you came from the mouth of God. The word for "formed" is the word for what a potter does with clay (it is used that way in Jeremiah 18). Notice how close God comes. In Genesis 1 he speaks from a distance. In Genesis 2 the text pictures him stooping like a potter over the clay, shaping a man and breathing into him. Then he plants a garden for him to live in.

He gave him work. "The LORD God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it" (Gen. 2:15). Work came before the fall, so work itself was never the curse. God worked six days, and the creature made in his image was given work to do: dominion with a spade in its hand. In Hebrew, "work" and "keep" are the same two verbs later used together for the Levites' service at the tabernacle (the Levites were the tribe God set apart to serve at his house), where English Bibles translate them "minister" and "keep guard" (Num. 3:7–8). Adam was a gardener, and he was something like a priest, tending the place where God met with man.

He gave him a command. "You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die" (Gen. 2:16–17). Look at the proportions: every tree, and one exception. The command was the shape of a relationship. Would Adam trust God's word about what is good, or decide good and evil for himself? Reformed Christians call this arrangement the covenant of works (the Shorter Catechism calls it the "covenant of life"). The Westminster Confession explains: "The first covenant made with man was a covenant of works, wherein life was promised to Adam; and in him to his posterity, upon condition of

perfect and personal obedience" (WCF 7.2). ("Posterity" means his descendants.) Adam stood as the head and representative of the whole human race, so what he did counted for all of us (Rom. 5:18–19; 1 Cor. 15:22; WSC 16). Next week we will see what that meant.

He gave him a wife. For the first time in the Bible, God says something is not good: "It is not good that the man should be alone" (Gen. 2:18). So he brings the animals to Adam to name, and none of them is a match. Then God puts him to sleep, takes a rib, and builds the woman, and brings her to him. Adam's response is the first human speech recorded in the Bible, and it comes out as a poem: "This at last is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh" (2:23). Then comes a sentence Jesus himself quoted as the words of the Creator: "Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife, and they shall become one flesh" (2:24; see Matt. 19:4–6). Then the chapter ends with a quiet line that will matter very much next week: "And the man and his wife were both naked and were not ashamed" (2:25). Nothing to hide. Nothing between them and God.

He gave him rest. Genesis 2 actually opens with the seventh day: God "rested on the seventh day from all his work that he had done. So God blessed the seventh day and made it holy" (2:2–3). Adam was made on the sixth day, so his first whole day in the world was a day of rest. God rested because he was finished, and satisfied, and he invited his image to share his rest. Jesus said, "The Sabbath was made for man" (Mark 2:27). From the first week of the world, rest was a gift.

Part Five: What Is Man?

Centuries later, David looked up at the same stars we read about last week and asked the question this whole lesson has been circling:

> **Psalm 8:3–6** *"When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet,"*

Both halves are true. Next to the universe, man is tiny. And God crowned him with glory and honor and put the world under his feet.

But look around. Does it look like the world is under our feet? We cannot keep our gardens weeded, let alone rule creation well. We bury the people we love. Our bodies break down. The book of Hebrews quotes Psalm 8 and then says honestly what we all can see: "At present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him" (Heb. 2:8). Something has gone terribly wrong with God's image. That is next week's lesson.

But Hebrews does not stop there. The very next words are these: “But we see him who for a little while was made lower than the angels, namely Jesus, crowned with glory and honor because of the suffering of death, so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone” (Heb. 2:9). (Hebrews quotes the ancient Greek translation of the psalm, which renders “heavenly beings” as “angels.”) We do not yet see the world under man’s feet. We do see one Man crowned.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Eden was the first place where God met with man. A river flowed from it, the tree of life stood in it, and Adam was set there to “work it and keep it,” the same words later used for priestly service. When God later builds a tabernacle and a temple, they will be full of garden images: cherubim (the mighty angelic guardians who will guard Eden’s gate in Genesis 3), a lampstand shaped like a tree, carved flowers and fruit. Every sanctuary after Eden is a picture of a garden lost and a way back being made.

THE LAMB Notice what is missing from the garden: there is no altar and no sacrifice. No one has died. There was no sin to cover and no shame to hide (Gen. 2:25). Hold on to that silence. In the very next chapter, something dies so that sinners can be covered (Gen. 3:21).

The Turn: The True Image

If you have been following closely, a question may be forming. If we were made in the image of God, why is that image so hard to see in us, and in me? Why do I so often reflect selfishness instead of God’s holiness, fear instead of his peace, and want to be served instead of to serve? Next week we will learn exactly how the image was defaced. But the Turn of this lesson is to see where the image is found whole.

> **Colossians 1:15** *“He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.”*

“Firstborn” here means first in rank, the heir over creation, not the first thing made. The very next verse says all things were created through him (Col. 1:16).

Jesus is the image of God that never failed. Adam was made in God’s image. The Son *is* God’s image. From all eternity he is “the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature” (Heb. 1:3). He became a man, the last Adam (1 Cor. 15:45), and as a man he wore the image perfectly. Where Adam would fail as our head, Jesus obeyed for his people (Rom. 5:19). He worked, and kept the garden of his Father’s will without a single failure. He ruled the wind and the waves. He loved God with all his heart and his neighbor as himself.

And the good news is that he did not come only to show us the image. He came to restore it in us. Those who belong to him, Paul says, “are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another” (2 Cor. 3:18). God’s plan is that they be “conformed to the image of his Son” (Rom. 8:29). The statue that was defaced is being carved again, by the same hands that formed Adam from the dust.

The Shorter Catechism opens with this very question: “What is the chief end of man?” Its answer: “Man’s chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy him for ever” (WSC 1).

So come back to the garage question. What are you for? You were made by God and in his image, to know him, reflect him, and care for his world. You have not lived up to that, and neither have I. But the true Image came, lived the life you were made for, and died to take away the sin that ruined you. If you turn from your sin and trust him, he will begin to make you, day by day, what you were always meant to be. And on the last day, John says, “we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2).

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the two chapters twice.** Read Genesis 1 out loud, slowly. Then read Genesis 2. Mark every “And God said” and every “it was good.”

2. **See the image in someone.** Pick one person you find hard to love. Each time you see them this week, tell yourself silently: a living statue of the King.

3. **Work as worship.** Before you start work one day this week, pray Genesis 2:15 over it: Lord, help me work it and keep it, for you.

4. **Keep the Lord’s Day.** This Sunday, worship with God’s people and rest from your ordinary work. Receive the day as a gift.

5. **Give thanks for the ordinary.** At one meal this week, name three things about it you did not make and could not make. “Everything created by God is good” (1 Tim. 4:4).

6. **Memorize Genesis 1:27.** “So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them.”

Before Lesson 4: *Read Genesis 3 and Romans 5:12–21. Lesson 4 is the darkest chapter in the story, and the first promise of a Rescuer.*

For Discussion

1. What answers does our culture give to the question “What are people for?” How does Genesis 1–2 answer it differently?
2. Look at the forming and filling pattern of the six days. What does it tell you about the kind of God who made the world?
3. Why does it matter that God called the physical world “very good”? Where have you seen Christians treat the body or the material world as less than good?
4. Kings set up images of themselves to mark their rule. What does it mean for you to be God’s “living image” in your home, work, and neighborhood?
5. Read Genesis 9:6 and James 3:9. How should the image of God shape the way we treat the unborn, the disabled, the elderly, people of other races, and our enemies?

6. Work, marriage, and rest were all given before sin entered the world. How does that change the way you think about each one?
7. Hebrews 2:8–9 says we do not yet see everything under man's feet, "but we see… Jesus." How is Jesus the answer to Psalm 8?

Sources & For Further Study

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